

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Menuridae

Lyrebirds

Length 35–39 in (90–100 cm)

Species 2



Lyrebirds occur in rainforests and scrub in east and southeast Australia. Of the 2 species, Albert's lyrebird is the smaller and has more chestnut plumage, while the superb lyrebird is grayer. Males of both species are known for their extravagant tail, which in the superb lyrebird can be up to 23½ in (60 cm) long, and has 2 distinctive lyre-shaped feathers. Male lyrebirds display from midwinter; while Albert's lyrebird treads

down a display platform of vines, the superb lyrebird rakes up numerous low display mounds around his territory. The male's powerful song includes impressive mimicry. While calling, he inverts his tail over his back, shimmering it and turning around slowly.

SUPERB LYREBIRD
Menura novaehollandiae, 34–39 in (86–100 cm) long, is found in southeast Australia and has been introduced in Tasmania. The male of this species does not acquire his full tail until he is 6–8 years old.



Family Atrichornithidae

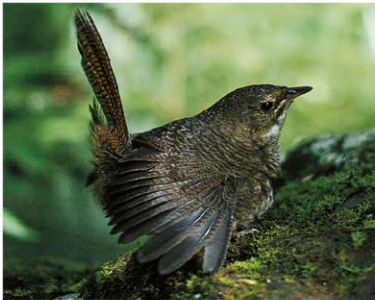
Scrubbirds

Length 6¼–9 in (16–23 cm)

Species 2



The distribution and population of these brown Australian birds have decreased since the mid-1800s. Secretive, they spend much of their time on the ground in thick cover, in wet forest. They feed on insects, lizards, and frogs. Both species of scrub-birds build domed nests.



RUFIOUS SCRUBBIRD
Atrichornis rufescens has a penetrating call but is extremely hard to locate. It is 6½–7 in (16.5–18 cm) long, and is a weak flier that scuttles in leaf litter like a mouse.

Family Orthonychidae

Logrunners

Length 6½–11 in (17–28 cm)

Species 3



The 3 secretive species of logrunners from forests of New Guinea and eastern Australia are weak-flying birds that live close to the ground. Here, they forage for insects, always preferring to run than fly when threatened. Their tails are spiny due to the stiff bare feather shafts that extend beyond the tips. Logrunners have loud, resonant, voices and one Australian species—the chowchilla—is named after its call. They build large dome nests out

of sticks and moss, placed close to the ground. Several other babblerlike birds were formerly classified in this family; Orthonychidae is now thought to be one of several small groups of ancient passerines restricted to Australasia.



AUSTRALIAN LOGRUNNER
Seen in pairs or family parties on the floor of the rainforest in southeastern Australia, Orthonyx temminckii is 7–8 in (18–20 cm) long.

Family Climacteridae

Australasian treecreepers

Length 4–7 in (10–17.5 cm)

Species 7



These birds from Australia and New Guinea are unrelated to true treecreepers of the Northern Hemisphere (Certhiidae) and, unlike them, do not use their tail as support, as they clamber around tree trunks. However, they have evolved to resemble them because of their otherwise similar habits. They have mostly brown plumage, thin, curved bills and strongly clawed feet, and they feed on insects and spiders plucked from tree bark; sometimes they forage on the ground. Their nest—a grassy cup—is usually placed in a tree cavity. Two or 3 eggs are incubated by both sexes.



WHITE-THROATED TREECREEPER
Cornobates leucophaeus, 6½–7 in (16–17.5 cm) long, occurs in eastern and southeastern Australia in a wide range of habitats.

Family Pardalotidae

Pardalotes

Length 3½–4½ in (9–12 cm)

Species 4



Pardalotes are small, short-tailed birds found in Australia. Three species are white-spotted to a variable degree (pardalote comes from a Greek word, meaning spotted); the fourth—the striated—has white head and wing stripes. They are insect-eaters and their stumpy bills are adapted for taking sap-sucking scale insects from leaves; like many other birds of the region, they also drink the sweet honeydew exuded by these and related insects—and are often in fierce competition with honeyeaters (see opposite) over sources of this energy-rich food. Pardalotes are typically birds of tall eucalyptus forest, where they feed in the canopy. They

Family Ptilonorhynchidae

Bowerbirds

Length 8½–15 in (21–38 cm)

Species 27



Male bowerbirds are well known for the elaborate bowers they create to attract females—these are complex structures decorated with brightly colored objects. They also decorate their display grounds (leks) with feathers, flowers, leaves, pebbles, and even clothes pins or colored bits of plastic and paper. They cohabit with one or more females and the latter rear the young. These birds are spread across New Guinea and Australia, where most inhabit damp forest, although some prefer drier areas. Bowerbirds are mainly fruit-eaters, but will also feed on leaves, flowers, seeds, and invertebrates, feeding at all levels from ground to canopy.



SATIN BOWERBIRD
Restricted to northeast and southeast Australia, Ptilonorhynchus violaceus is 12 in (30 cm) long. The glossy, blue-black male—the most photographed bowerbird—builds an “avenue” bower of sticks, decorating it with bright blue or yellow objects. This bird has a pale yellow bill.

descend to earth banks to build their nests in holes, but sometimes nest in tree holes; a clutch consists of 2–5 white eggs. Pardalotes were previously classified with flowerpeckers (p.366), but are now thought to be more closely related to Australasian warblers.



STRIATED PARDALOTE
Endemic to Australia, Pardalotus striatus is common in eucalyptus forest and other types of woodland. It is about 4 in (10 cm) long. There are at least 5 geographically variable populations, with either black or striped crowns.